Interview answers

Harrie, from Bandung, now in Jakarta. Topic: forest and land fires (karhutla) in Indonesia.

QUESTION 1 OF 15

Could you briefly introduce yourself and explain why you decided to join the protests?

I'm Harrie, from Bandung, now in Jakarta. I'm a young Indonesian. I joined the protest in Jakarta because we keep hearing that the fires are "under control," and the smoke says otherwise. You can't breathe a press statement. So I came out. We have to break the pattern today, or the loop will repeat tomorrow.

QUESTION 2 OF 15

What is the main issue that you and other young Indonesians are protesting about?

People are breathing smoke. That's the issue. Not next year, not in a report. Now. And it's not only people. Animals are suffering too: orangutans losing the forests they live in, wildlife burned or driven out of their homes, and none of them can protest.

And every dry season the same fires come back, and every time we're told it's a surprise. It's not a surprise. It's a pattern that nobody wants to be accountable for.

QUESTION 3 OF 15

How would you describe the current fire situation in Indonesia? What are you seeing on the ground?

To get a clear picture of the current situation, I built an open-source project called Visualize Karhutla. It maps satellite data from NASA across Kalimantan, Sumatra and Papua, and it shows more than 435,000 hotspots in 2026, as of 17 October.

A hotspot isn't a confirmed fire, it's a heat signal. I'm saying that because facts matter, and because the real situation could be milder or worse. Some reports say more than 1.9 million hectares have burned, others give different numbers. That's the problem. Open the data, and nobody has to guess.

QUESTION 4 OF 15

How have the fires affected you, your family or your community?

The fires haven't hit me directly. But people in my community have family and friends living under that smoke. I don't need smoke at my door to know it's real. Someone else is already breathing it.

QUESTION 5 OF 15

What do you believe is causing the fires, and who do you think should be held responsible?

Most fires are set by people, often to clear land. They spread fast on drained peat in a long dry season. This has been known for years.

I won't name anyone, because satellite data can't tell who lit a fire or who owns the land. But whoever it is, they have to be found and held responsible, company or individual. Investigations, permit checks, enforcement. Before the next dry season, not after.

QUESTION 6 OF 15

Do you see the fires as an isolated crisis, or are they part of a wider problem in Indonesia?

It's wider. Land clearing, weak oversight of permits, drained peatlands, and a changing climate. And it's not only Kalimantan. South Sumatra and Merauke have huge hotspot counts too, and they get a fraction of the attention. We should be asking why.

QUESTION 7 OF 15

What are your main demands of the government?

We have four demands, and each one starts with a verb, because we want action.

- **KEBUT.** Speed up the emergency response for as long as the fires and the smoke are still happening.
- **TUNTUT.** Demand compensation and damages, until residents' losses are actually followed up.
- **USUT.** Investigate the violations of the law until they are held accountable.
- **RAJUT.** Weave together recovery after the disaster, and prevention of future fires.

These aren't extreme. They're the minimum.

QUESTION 8 OF 15

What specifically do you want President Prabowo's government to do?

Treat this as the national emergency it is. Coordinate the ministries. Publish the data. Show us the investigations, and what came out of them. And protect people who speak up, whether they report fires or protest peacefully. That shouldn't need to be asked.

QUESTION 9 OF 15

What do you think of the government's response so far?

There's a response, but it's not enough. The government announced Rp760 billion in contingency funds for seven provinces and says it respects freedom of expression. Those are words, and money helps. But people don't breathe words. We need results: cleaner air, fires stopped early, cases that reach court.

On 20 October, Greenpeace activists unfurled a banner at Bundaran HI, on the government's second anniversary, and it was reportedly taken down quickly. The fires haven't been put out that quickly. The government said it will evaluate and asked for data. Then evaluate, and then act.

QUESTION 10 OF 15

What do you think the government has failed to do?

Prevention. Every year: fires, then smoke, then a response that's always late. And the public still can't see who is responsible, how permits are monitored, or what happened to past cases. That's not a technical gap. That's a failure of accountability.

QUESTION 11 OF 15

Are you calling for emergency assistance, investigations into the causes of the fires, punishment for those responsible, or longer-term policy changes?

All of it, in order. Emergency aid first, because people are sick now. Investigations, so we know the causes. Punishment based on evidence. And long-term change, because otherwise we'll be here again next year with the same smoke and the same statements.

QUESTION 12 OF 15

Have the protests led to any concrete results so far?

It's early. After the protests, the government said it would evaluate and talked about funds. I can't say the protests caused that, but the response came after people showed up. So the question is simple: will it continue once the headlines are gone?

QUESTION 13 OF 15

Why do you think young Indonesians are particularly concerned about this issue?

Because it's our future. We'll live with the consequences the longest. We grew up online, so we can read the data, share it, and ask hard questions. And you don't have to protest only in the street. Art is protest. Stories are protest. Data is protest. Writing is protest. Everyone can do something, and everyone should.

QUESTION 14 OF 15

What will you and other protesters do if the government does not meet your demands?

No progress without protest. That's not a slogan, that's history. So we keep going, peacefully, in every form we can: in the street, through art, stories, data, writing, and at the ballot box. If our demands aren't met, we raise the pressure. We're not going away.

QUESTION 15 OF 15

What would convince you that the government is taking your concerns seriously?

Open data. Public investigation results. Visible enforcement. Fires put out before they become a crisis. And a budget for prevention, not just for cleaning up after the news cycle. We don't need promises, we need results. Show us, and we'll say so.

But if the government keeps letting us burn like this, then if we burn, they have to burn with us. Not with fire. With accountability: in public, at the ballot box, and under the law.

Notes: A hotspot is a satellite-detected heat signal, not a confirmed fire. Hotspot figures are from NASA FIRMS (VIIRS NOAA-20), 1 January to 17 October 2026. Burned-area figures differ between sources and periods. The Rp760 billion contingency fund and the 20 October Greenpeace action at Bundaran HI are as reported by Indonesian media.